

important event of the year. Featuring snake-boat races, traditional Kaikottikali story-dances, and intricate flower carpets, the festivities culminate with the Thiruvonam feast of Onasadya, a nine-course banquet of exquisite vegetarian dishes, served on banana leaves. www.onamfestival.org

NORTH AMERICA

Howell Melon Festival, Michigan, USA

The delicious variety of cantaloupe melon found only in these parts was brought to Howell in seed form by a hobo during the Depression. His gift is honored every August with parades and parties, tastings of melon wine and ice cream, art exhibits and face painting (look like a melon!), and the sale of over 20,000 fine, ripe fruits. www.howellmelonfestival.com

Fête des Cuisinières, Point-à-Pitre, Guadeloupe

Where better for a festival of women cooks than this lovely French-Caribbean island? On the feast day of St-Laurent, the patron saint of chefs, over 200 *cuisinières* from all over the West Indies, in gorgeous Creole costumes, parade their dishes through the streets to the church to be blessed. The free five-hour gourmet banquet that follows is open to all.

Fête de la Poutine, Drummondville, Quebec, Canada

This lively weekend of music and family fun permits everyone to indulge in a little too much of the unofficial Quebecois national dish, *poutine* – a mushy but irresistible concoction of French fries, cheese curds, and rich brown gravy. Infinite varieties exist, many of which can be sampled here for as long as your appetite holds out. www.festivaldelapoutine.com

SOUTH AMERICA

Otro Sabor, Medellín, Colombia

In the beautiful setting of Medellín's Botanical Gardens, chefs and gourmets from Colombia, Latin America, and the world come together for this celebration of food and flavors. From the simple cornbread *arepa* to the 13-element *paisa* platter (ranging from avocado to pork rind), there's plenty to sample.

SEPTEMBER

EUROPE

Galway Oyster Fest, Ireland

Follow the colorful parade through the streets, then dig in to new-season oysters with smoked salmon, crab claws, seafood chowder, and chilled white wine. Not to mention the Guinness World Oyster Opening Championship finals, a gala ball, and the Saturday Oyster Trail, when 40 hostelryes offer free oysters and live music. www.galwayoysterfest.com

Pizzafest, Naples, Italy

Naples' tantalizing ten-day festival honors their most famous culinary creation. But even before you get your hands on a pizza, the teasing aroma of freshly-baked marinara, Margherita, calzone, and *quattro stagioni*, wafting from wood-fired ovens all over the city, will have your mouth watering. Events include music, theater, and workshops.

Oktoberfest, Munich, Germany

Biggest? Oldest? Best? Superlatives can't describe this 200-year-old extravaganza, where over 6 million revelers consume 2 million gallons of beer. But don't forget the roast meats, fish, dumplings, pretzels, and, of course, sauerkraut and sausages, all served by energetic waiting staff wearing those famous dirndls and lederhosen. www.oktoberfest.de

Brick Lane Curry Festival, London, UK

Every year, Brick Lane, London's world-famous "Curry Mile," explodes with color and aromas as Bangla Town's fabulous feast inspires tens of thousands to savor every tongue-tingling spicy taste imaginable. Over 40 restaurants display their very best dishes to be tasted and enjoyed, to the vibrant sounds of the music festival. www.curryfestival.co/

THE MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA

Soweto Wine Festival, Johannesburg, South Africa

What began in 2004 as a crazy dream around a braai in Pretoria has matured into South Africa's most up-and-coming,

trendsetting wine event. Three nights of tutored wine and food tastings, featuring over 800 wines, might sound like any other show, but this is Soweto-style, with spicy food and cool jazz. www.sowetowinefestival.co.za

ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Mooncake Festival, China

Also called the Mid-Autumn or Moon Festival, this nationwide event is honored with music, dancing, and mooncakes. These beautifully decorated pastry pies are on sale in every bakery. They're filled with a sweet bean or lotus seed paste, wrapped around a salted duck egg yolk representing the moon. Cut into small wedges, they're eaten while watching the full moon rise.

NORTH AMERICA

Posen Potato Festival, Michigan, USA

On the first weekend after Labor Day, the tiny town of Posen goes back to its Polish roots with traditional costumes, crafts, music, polka dancing, and potatoes. Entrants to the Potato Cooking Competition have no chance of beating Beatrice Richard's record – she notched up her 47th win with her Cheeseburger Soup recipe (secret ingredient: potatoes).

Feast of San Gennaro, New York City, USA

New York's Little Italy may be a shadow of its former self, but not when New York's biggest, oldest, and most revered festival bursts on to the streets. Processions, feasts, and festivities last 11 days, during which religious devotion and good eating go hand in hand. Don't miss the statue of San Gennaro being paraded through the streets – or the Cannoli Eating Competition. www.sangennaro.org

SOUTH AMERICA

Mistura, Lima, Peru

Mistura is a showcase for 7,000 years of Peruvian cuisine and produce. Hand-picked representatives, from street vendors and country cooks to gourmet chefs, demonstrate and serve every style of cooking. Adventurous diners can even sample roast *cuy* (guinea pig). Traditional and modern Peruvian music and a lively market and bazaar add to the unique flavor of the event. www.mistura.pe

From left to right New-season oysters on display at the Whitstable Oyster Festival, England; different varieties of mooncake eaten during China's Mooncake Festival in September; revelers getting messy during Spain's La Tomatina in August; crowds throng on Clarke Quay's Food Street during the Singapore Food Festival

